

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 163

Culture (OWC): [Ovambo \(FX08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1924-1976

Coverage Date: 1900 AD - 1965 AD

Place Coverage

north-central Namibia; Cunene Province, Angola

Section Title(S): 2. Proverbs And Riddles

On this point there is a curious error in the *Wörterbuch der Ovambo-Sprache Osikwanjama-Deutsch* by the missionary Tönjes. To him the word *omuse* means nothing but a bush whose fruits of the same name have a very bitter taste. [Tönjes cites the following phrases:] *Okuumba omise*: "throw bitter fruits" = "say disagreeable things." *Otumbu-ŋge omise*: "say words as bitter as those fruits" (Tönjes, 1910, p. 152). We see here how a man who is the author of a monograph concerning the Kwanyama, the author of a grammar and of a little dictionary, was deceived by appearances to the point of identifying the word *omuse*, which signifies the bush in question, with the homonym which has the sense of proverb! But there is no doubt that different words are involved. In the neighboring regions the bush either does not exist or has a different name, but the languages of these regions all employ the term *omuse* or *omube* to designate a proverb.

114
Reviews And Critiques

5310
Verbal Arts

A word about the verb that is always used in connection with this noun, meaning "to say a proverb." It is the verb *okuumba* or *okuyumba*, "to throw." In Kwanyama the same term is used for "to shoot." *Okuumba outa* is to fire a musket or to shoot an arrow from a bow. It is clear that the idea of *throwing* a joke and even of wounding is often linked to the employment of a proverb. And this fact, as will be readily understood, contributed much to Tönjes's confusion. We should be exaggerating, however, if we translated *okuumba omuse* by "to shoot a proverb," as if a pointed missile were involved. It is one of the etymologically violent expressions of the language which have been worn down with use.

114
Reviews And Critiques

5310
Verbal Arts

From all these explanations it will be seen that when used with judgment and discretion the proverbs are manifestations of common sense and popular wisdom, as they are all over the world, and not infrequently score points in the interminable litigations of our natives. This is the idea that is expressed in one of the aphorisms, to wit: *Hamuse waumba elai* ("A fool does not know how to use proverbs").

114
Reviews And Critiques

5310
Verbal Arts

Now let me give a selection of *omise*, but without attempting to group them by subject.

128
Organization And
Analysis Of Results

To a person who is about to leave a country to flee from poverty, they say, *Na ku toi, oso sili-ko* ("Wherever you go, the same thing is there").

5310
Verbal Arts

We consider the natives not very frank and often full of reticence in their speech. Among themselves they complain of the same thing: *Sili m'oñulo yamukweni, kusisi* ("You do not know what is in another's heart").

5310
Verbal Arts

Idleness is stigmatized in a very realistic way: *Omufeni wetondo, 164 omutumba ihaueta-sa* ("Wearing out the parts hidden on a seat [being seated] brings nothing [home]").

5310
Verbal Arts

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)